Exploration | Body

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by riverblaster

Summary

The trio visit a private resort for rest and relaxation and after a physically demanding hike and a few tumbles, they finally get it. And then some dude walks in on them. Rude.

"Oh, come now, it's not so different from an expedition!" Emilie said brightly, leading the way through the dense foliage. "I'm sure we'll find it soon!"

"Or die trying," Nathalie replied drily, climbing over tree roots. She held a low branch to the side for Gabriel, who nodded thankfully at her as he passed, hurrying after his wife.

"I'm afraid I'm starting to agree with Nathalie, Emilie," he jogged to catch up with her, Nathalie following closely behind. "You said it was only supposed to be fifteen minutes from the resort, but we've been walking for almost an hour, and neither you nor I are properly dressed for a hike."

"You're both buzzkills!" Emilie teased. She finally stopped to face him, one hand to her sun hat to hold it in place. Her short pink sundress, covered with white tropical flower print, swirled around her. "I'm not sure *what* you're worried about; this island has no predatory animals on it!"

"Which means you can't get hurt?" Nathalie raised an eyebrow and crossed her arms, unimpressed and unconvinced. It was a very weak argument, though Emilie was right about one thing - the island was almost entirely man-made, purely with the purpose of being fun for the rich and famous, and, as such, it hosted zero predatory animals outside of any purse dogs the guests brought with them.

Emilie leaned into Nathalie's side with the same smile she used every time she wanted something to go her way. "If I *do* get hurt, I'm sure *you'll* make it *better*, won't you, Nathalie?"

A soft pink dusted Nathalie's cheeks, thankfully unnoticed thanks to the dense shade the forest offered them. "Not getting hurt at all is better than healing from an injury, Emilie," she replied, not falling for Emilie's game. She thought about letting herself get drawn in, thought about the press of those glossy lips to her own, but her willpower won out.

Emilie huffed and instead turned to Gabriel, allowing Nathalie to breathe again. She leaned into his chest, wrapping her arms around his neck, and offered him that same smile. "I thought *you* were excited to see it, Gabriel," she cooed, pouting. "You said it might just be the inspiration you've been looking for for your next line."

Gabriel resolutely avoided her eyes, trying not to fall into her trap. "Well, yes, that- thats *true*, but-"

"And *besides*, we don't have anything *else* to do, do we? After all, we *are* on vacation," Emilie purred, nuzzling into his neck. (Nathalie grimaced on her behalf; she knew Emilie hated the feeling of other people's sweat, yet she was so determined to continue forward she ignored that discomfort). "And once we have *a bouncing baby boy* on our hands, we won't have *any* time left to do things like this..."

Gabriel swallowed. Nathalie's eyes narrowed; she knew from experience what was coming next. They locked eyes.

"Nathalie..." he started, smiling shyly. His cheeks were pink, his expression dopey. *Whipped*, one might say. "Would you mind...?"

Nathalie subtly sighed. Sure, it was nice of them to bring her along to the resort and pay for her stay; Emilie even touted it as a vacation she'd *earned* after almost two years spent searching for the Miraculous without any luck. Still, when Nathalie'd agreed to come, she'd hoped she'd get some actual *rest and relaxation* in; instead, Emilie had unilaterally decided the three of them needed to try *every activity* the resort and island offered them, and dragged Nathalie and Gabriel from dawn to dusk (and occasionally later than that, if there was something that piqued her attention) wherever she thought an adventure could be found. *This* was the latest one; after getting closer with some of the hotel staff, Emilie learned about a hidden oasis in the jungle, supposedly so beautiful it could count as a secret wonder of the world. The blonde wasted no time setting out in search of it with her lovers in tow - though, unfortunately, her sense of direction was rather poor, which was why they were currently lost. Still, with both and Gabriel now looking hopefully to Nathalie to find it, she knew she had little choice.

She turned to the towering tree beside her. "If I don't see it, we return to the hotel," she stated (bargained, begged).

"Whatever you say," Emilie agreed slyly, clearly showing no signs of sticking to that plan if it came down to it.

Nathalie sighed again, this time audibly, and began to climb. Unlike Emilie and Gabriel, who were both dressed like rich tourists - which meant they were dressed more for *looks* rather than for comfort or durability - Nathalie had opted to wear clothing more suited to movement; her beige shorts, plain but durable, and unpatterned button up shirt, sleeves rolled up to the elbow and top buttons open for comfort, would be well suited to her task, and her water shoes, though not meant for this, would work well enough in a pinch for grip. She quickly stretched her arms, interlocked her fingers and popped them, and then began to climb.

"See you soon!" Emilie cheered, waving a stolen handkerchief of Gabriel's.

"And be careful!" Gabriel called after her, looking somewhat guilty about her having to climb up there (though obviously not enough to call her down).

For an impromptu tree climb, the conditions were, Nathalie was thankful for, utterly *perfect*; no recent rain meant her handholds were dry, a pleasant breeze blew at semi-regular intervals, and it seemed the branches were in just the right locations and just the right thickness for her to safely grab without straining herself or needing to alter her route. Gabriel and Emilie, watching her climb, grew smaller and smaller on the ground as she moved upwards. Hand, foot, hand, foot, on and on, the bark passed just a few inches from her nose as she kept her eye on the next branch she would grab. She stopped periodically to glance out across the forest, hoping to see the supposed oasis without having to fully scale the tree, though it made no appearance; she somewhat expected it not to be real, a lie told to Emilie as a way to mess with her. Eventually, after a long enough time to have felt the air grow warmer as the highest heat of the day approached, she popped her head out above the canopy of the trees, nestled at the top of the one she was on. Here, the breeze was stronger, enough to make the top of the

tree sway, and she grit her teeth and tightened her grip, wrapping one muscular thigh around the narrow trunk to ensure she didn't fall.

Tropical birds cawed in the lower levels of the canopy as she looked around herself. The island the resort was built upon was a decent size, enough so that the guests could believe themselves truly "*away from it all*", and the forest stretched from one end of the island to the other, nestled inside a ring of white sandy beach. She saw the hotel to the west, a great big eye sore that she knew looked beautiful to those that paid for its exclusivity (Gabriel and Emilie included), and the blue ocean twinkled in the sunlight beyond it. The forest itself was largely all the same from this high up, with little of note beyond the varying shades of green the various leaves could offer. After searching for a few minutes, long enough for her sweat to dry from the breeze but her core temperature to rise from the sun beating down on her, she was preparing to climb down when she noticed something. There, in the distance, was a dip in a portion of forest to the west, not very far from the hotel; there was a small ring of space there that looked to be lacking tree cover, and though she was too far away to see inside of it for sure, she suspected their prize lay there. With an unenthusiastic exhale, she began to climb back down.

"Did you see anything?" Emilie asked a few minutes later as Nathalie took her final step down. Her speed betrayed her eagerness, her hope palpable; she looked almost like a little girl then, all of her worldly hopes balanced for just one moment on the hidden retreat she longed for.

Nathalie wiped her hands on her shirt, smearing sticky tree sap against the breathable fabric. "I didn't see anything definitively..." she replied, face impassive. Emilie's face fell and Nathalie bit her tongue so she wouldn't ruin the surprise. "*But*," she continued after Emilie stewed for a moment, "I saw the area it *most likely* is." She smiled as Emilie cheered, her tan arms thrown up in the air as she whooped, looking over at Gabriel to ensure he was just as excited. "We passed it; we must've gone around it without realizing."

"Well, what are you waiting for?! Lead the way!" Emilie urged Nathalie forward with a light shove, her smile almost overtaking her face. Nathalie, looked back at her with a frown, and when Emilie's smile grew embarrassed and hopeful, only *then* did Nathalie begin to walk, the other two quickly following after her.

Emilie talked animatedly as they walked, filling the silence the best way she knew how. She always had a story or a joke, some observation or gripe, and her two person audience always listened aptly as though they were born to do so. Something about Emilie made people *want* to make her happy, and there were none more so than the two traveling now with her who wanted and could best do so. Even without realizing it, Gabriel and Nathalie now both walked faster and with more pep in their steps, Emilie's boundless energy bleeding into them. Sometimes, Emilie would slow down so they could catch up to her, and lace her hands with their until their palms began to sweat and she pulled out of their grip; other times, she would seemingly have a great burst of excited energy and rush forward, like she wanted to play tag with them, and they would have no choice but to run after her, the three of them like school children playing a game.

"We should be nearing the area," Nathalie announced a few minutes later, her steps slowing. Her head swiveled slowly as she said, "Keep your eyes peeled."

Gabriel and Emilie followed her lead and slowed, looking around themselves. Emilie, the most excited and least cautious, hummed happily, pushing aside bushes and branches as she searched with reckless abandon, nearly hitting Gabriel with them multiple times as he trailed after her. After a few minutes of this, he broke away from her and began searching by himself, sparing himself face fulls of leaves; he was slightly more cautious, enough that he was at least aware of his surroundings as he walked, and that was a relief in itself, Nathalie grateful she didn't have to dodge any flora flying at her own head. The three spread out, stepping over tree roots and peering around trunks as though the oasis would suddenly appear larger than life the second they laid eyes on it.

Suddenly, without any warning, Emilie yelped. The sound was quickly followed by the sound of something falling and the noise of leaves being disturbed and her own grunts as she slid.

"Emilie?!" Gabriel and Nathalie both yelled, twin looks of fear upon their faces as they both looked around themselves, trying to spot her. The sound of sliding stopped as she obviously settled wherever she landed.

"Emilie, are you alright?!" Nathalie called, stepping towards where she last saw the blonde. It was a terrifying moment, the birds of the forest scared into silence for a moment, as they waited for her reply.

The sound of breathless laughter bubbled up in the silence and grew louder as Emilie, it seemed, recovered from her shock. Nathalie released a breath she'd been holding; Emilie was, at the very least, alive and okay enough to see humor in the situation - that alone was worth something.

"Nathalie, over here!" Gabriel called, standing near a large flowering bush nestled between two trees. Nathalie raced over to him, face grim; over the various expeditions Nathalie had been on in her life, both before and during her employ with the Agrestes, she'd had to perform first aid upon other people, and she worried this would be no exception. Gabriel clearly felt the same, his face white and his voice shaking.

It was, depending on who you asked, either a *steep hill* or a *small cliff*, not actually very tall at all. It was easy to overlook given the way the surroundings all blended together, very few notable landmarks actually alluding to its presence; Gabriel wouldn't have noticed it at all if not for Emilie's white sandal, perched precariously on the edge that was hidden by the bush. From there, it was easy to see the displacement of leaves and small foliage, clumps of dirt kicked out of the way and the flowers and leaves that were, it seemed, pulled off of the bush as Emilie fell and reached out for a handhold. Though the area around the lower elevation was rich with trees, the area inside of the lower elevation had few, with the ones that *were* present sparsely placed. The sun shone brightly here, unimpeded by the canopy, and the dirt was a rich brown underfoot, the air rich with its scent. At the bottom, Emilie lay on her back in the dirt, laughing, her chest fluttering with the movement. She had leaves and sticks stuck in her hair and dirt smeared across her skin, though she was clearly in good spirits as Nathalie and Gabriel surfed down to her.

"Are you alright?!" Gabriel asked, frenzied and half panicked. Kneeling beside her, he clasped her hand in both of his as she sat up, still giggling to herself.

"I'm *fine*, my love, perfectly fine!" she grinned, her face full of color and life. Nathalie sighed and felt her heart begin to calm as Emilie said, "And, see, *that's* why I don't model for you!"

His smile was soft, loving, and ultimately *relieved* as he replied, "Should I stop asking, then?"

Lips pursed playfully, she said, "Well, I didn't say *that*...." She brushed her hair out of her face, pulling a leaf out of it, then held her hand out to him and ordered, "Alright, help me up!"

With a soft smile, Gabriel sat back. With her sandal in hand, he held it out to her.

She giggled. "My knight in shining armor," she teased, though her smile was soft and loving. Like Cinderella and the prince, she slid her foot into the sandal and let him buckle it shut. Her eye twitched slightly, a minute change that Gabriel didn't notice but which Nathalie did.

Gabriel stood up, then offered her his hand like the knight she compared him to. She took it and pushed herself up with her free hand as he pulled; a moment later she was suddenly standing in front of him, chest to chest. She grinned and stepped back- then immediately hissed in pain, face crumpling.

Finally, Nathalie stepped forward, body tense. "Emilie, are you-" she started, eyes narrow.

"I'm- *fine*, Nathalie, *really*," Emilie stressed, her smile thin. "My ankle is just-"

"*Let me see*," Nathalie cut her off, kneeling on one knee in front of her.

"I *really* don't think that's-"

"Go on, my love," Gabriel urged, his smile unable to hide his sudden wariness. "Just to ease her mind."

"And *yours*?" Emilie shot back, glaring childishly. He flinched and guiltily looked away, though didn't deny it. With a huff, she leaned against him as she lifted her leg for Nathalie. With gentle hands, Nathalie caught her calf and held it steady as she gently twisted and turned her leg, keeping an eye on her ankle. Aside from some dirt and redness, a scrape here and there, it looked mostly as usual. Nathalie lightly prodded it, and when Emilie merely grimaced, she did it again slightly harder until Emilie gasped, hand tightening in Gabriel's shirt.

Nathalie hummed impassively. "Can you put weight on it?" she asked, releasing Emilie's leg.

Emilie slowly lowered her leg and tested it, uncomfortable. "Yes, but it's a little sore."

"We could call the resort and have them come pick us up in one of their carts," Gabriel suggested helpfully, hand already reaching into his pocket to grab his phone.

Emilie shot him an imperious glare. "It *really* isn't that serious, Gabriel."

"I agree," Nathalie nodded, standing up. She dusted off the knees of her pants. "It looks like she just twisted it. If we put ice on it, it'll probably be fine by tomorrow."

"It's no worse than wearing heels and slipping," Emilie waved her hand dismissively. "Now, let's keep looking; we're close, I can *feel* it!"

Gabriel looked uncomfortable. "We could always look again tomorrow," he suggested, shifting on his feet and not looking directly at her; it was obvious he knew the reaction he would get.

"You'll try to talk me out of it!" Emilie shook her head, a slightly spoiled whine in her voice. "I've already said I'm alright, and besides, don't you think a refreshing swim in some *nice, cool water* will do just as much good as ice?"

Gabriel's grimace deepened. "I'm not sure, Emilie... We have plenty of time, do we not? Perhaps taking the rest of the day to rest would be-"

"An entire day? It's only a twisted ankle; I'm sure you've done worse just sleeping in your atelier overnight!" she argued, her glare cool.

Neither unwilling to back down, they both looked to Nathalie, who stiffened.

"What do *you* think, Nathalie?" he asked softly, hoping for guidance.

"Tell him I'm fine, Nathalie!" Emilie argued. "You *know* I am!"

Nathalie chewed the inside of her cheek for a moment, then sighed. "It's only a twisted ankle and Emilie isn't going to let up. I don't see the harm in looking for a little longer."

Emilie cheered as Gabriel asked, "You're sure?"

Nathalie nodded. "As long as she doesn't strain it, she should be fine. Besides..." she smiled wryly. "She would probably make us regret it otherwise."

Gabriel sighed, a slight smile to his own mouth. "Well... it seems I've been outvoted," he said. "But that doesn't mean I can't take care of you in *other* ways, my love."

Emilie's cheeks reddened. "Gabriel, you don't mean-"

With a quick motion, he swept her up into a bridal carry, to her shock and merriment. "There's no reason to walk on that foot," he teased, pressing his face into her neck to lightly kiss her skin. "Not while I'm here to uplift you, anyway." He glanced over at Nathalie with a mischievous smile. "Besides, I can't have *Nathalie* win all of your favor, can I?"

Emilie laughed and lightly slapped his chest as Nathalie, smirking, said, "Be careful making this a competition, Gabriel; you know I never lose." They grinned at each other.

"Well, there's no time to waste!" Emilie brightly spoke up. "You can both compete for my affection while we look for that oasis! First person to find it gets a kiss; chop chop!"

it was a paltry prize, given the fact that she kissed both of them multiple times every day, though neither of them argued; her kisses were the most addicting substance on earth, after all, second only to the entirety of her. Though they didn't go as far as to outright race, they *did* both walk slightly faster.

The trees, growing as sparsely as they were, offered little in the way of shade as the day grew brighter. Birds chirped overhead, feathers in every color of the rainbow gleaming in the sunlight as they flew. The sound of running water gradually appeared, no longer able to overlook.

"Do you hear that?" Emilie asked, excited. Her head turned left and right and she squirmed in Gabriel's grip, slowing his walk as he struggled not to drop her. "I can hear water; we must be close!"

"Emilie, please-" Gabriel begged, flustered. One hand dug into into the fat of her thigh as the other held tight to her ribs; it was an enviable hold, certainly.

Nathalie found the source of the sound first, not a grotto but rather a flowing stream, the water clear and not very deep. It was refreshingly cool in a way that made Nathalie suddenly realize that she'd been slightly too warm to be comfortable this entire time; she dipped her hands in the water and let the current slide over them and through her fingers. She raised her hands next to her neck and rubbed them over the skin there, letting the water drip down and into her shirt to cool herself.

"Just a stream," Gabriel muttered quietly, disappointed as he, still with his wife in his arms, stepped up to the bank beside Nathalie. "Emilie, are you *sure* the workers said it was more than *this*?"

She glared at him and crossed her arms. "Of course I'm sure! They said it was deep enough to swim in. *And* that there was a waterfall!"

"Perhaps they were pranking you," he suggested, echoing Nathalie's earlier fear. He looked far more tired than he had been at the start of their search. Nathalie wanted to suggest he cool himself in the stream as well, though she held her tongue, not wanting to interrupt.

"*Pranking*-?!" Emilie gasped angrily. "Why on *earth* would they do that?!" Her face was red, surely just as much from anger as it was from the heat, and the sun beating down on her seemed only to strengthen her unhappiness.

Sensing his mistake, he hesitated before saying, "...Because you have such adorable reactions?"

While Gabriel tried to calm Emilie, Nathalie examined the stream. The water was flowing to the south, small debris dams occasionally scattered near the banks. To the north, the water flowed from a point in the forest they had been making their way towards before Nathalie scaled the tree, while further south, the water disappeared into the trees.

Ignoring the unhappy couple, she frowned at the sparkling stream and debated. If they followed the river *north*, they could theoretically stumble upon an oasis from which the stream *originated*. On the other hand, if they flowed the stream *south*, they could theoretically find an oasis it *emptied out* into. There was also every possibility the stream didn't connect to the oasis at all, and that following it would only lead them further away from their destination. She could've climbed another tree, but the trees in this area of the forest were shorter than the one she climbed previously, which had already failed to give her a glimpse at their longed for destination, so she doubted climbing one would help them any now; she could rely only on her own smarts to get them to the oasis.

After a moment, she straightened and turned to the Agrestes. "Let's follow the river," she interrupted, pointing the way the water flowed. "It might empty into the grotto."

Emilie looked vindicated. "That is a *wonderful* idea, Nathalie!" she praised, pointedly ignoring Gabriel as he winced. "Maybe *you* should carry me instead."

"Emilie, *please*!" Gabriel looked and sounded hurt, his expression as horrified as if she'd told him she wanted a divorce.

Nathalie dipped her head, smiling wryly. "I would, but I'm afraid you're too distracting; we might not find anything if I'm busy holding you." She didn't react to the appreciative look Gabriel sent her way.

Emilie giggled, then sighed dramatically, slumping in Gabriel's arms as though swooning. "Nice excuse," she teased. "*Fine*, fine, you're off the hook just this once. Now, let's go!"

The trio set off, following the water closely. Emilie hummed happily, sometimes whistling along with the birds when the mood struck. Gabriel's voice joined Emilie's on occasion, quietly singing along to melodies he recognized, though he seemed most focused on not dropping his wife and not tripping. The air by the stream was cooler and refreshing, enough to at least offer some comfort, and Nathalie passed the time by mentally noting the different flora and fauna she saw; the island was a sort of ecological melting pot, featuring several different plants and animals from various tropical regions across the globe which would have otherwise never interacted with each other. After only a few minutes of walking, the bank began to grow rocky and the trees grew sparse. The stream seemed to rush faster, growing wider and somewhat deeper as, it seemed, it swelled with groundwater.

Emilie's excitement was palpable as, a few minutes later, they finally cleared the last of the trees, exiting at the *top of a waterfall* the stream fed into. She cheered, startling some nearby birds into flight, and threw her arms up, nearly punching Gabriel by accident.

"I *told you*, Gabriel!" she taunted victoriously. "I told you!!!"

Gabriel's own grin was relieved; he looked happy to be proven wrong. "I should've known you would be," he dipped his head and put his face in her hair. "You always are."

"And don't you ever forget that," Emilie poked him in the chest, grinning. "Now, put me down; I want to see!"

"But your ankle-"

"Oh, please, Gabriel?" she asked, her excited expression turning immediately into a sweet, sad one, her acting ability on display. "Don't make me beg."

Gabriel set Emilie down delicately as Nathalie examined the area. The waterfall was between 15-20 feet (4.5-6 meters) tall, and the plunge pool at the bottom seemed deep. Leaning over the side, the cool spray washing over Nathalie, she could see an easy to climb wall leading up to the top of the waterfall, far enough away from the water that it wouldn't be treacherous to climb. From this height, she could just make out a path through the forest at the bottom that she suspected led back to the hotel on an incline; it connected, it seemed, to another path that took a slightly longer route up to the waterfall, which was convenient for anybody who couldn't climb. It was, it could be said, certainly a beautiful area (though perhaps not quite on the level of a world wonder), and she could understand easily why the hotel employees came here to enjoy themselves far away from the spoiled guests of the hotel.

"It's marvelous," Gabriel said beside her, grinning as he looked out across the space. His hand twitched at his pocket, where his notebook resided, no doubt excited to start sketching, but his smile was soft and his attention was focused only on her. "And we have *you* to thank, of course. I should've known with you leading the way we would get here no matter what."

Nathalie's eyes widened and she found herself blushing. She cleared her throat and shyly looked away. "I'm glad I could be of servi-"

The sound of pitter-pattering feet distracted her. She looked up just in time to watch Emilie, hobbling as she ran, *throw* herself over the edge.

"*WOOHOO*!" Emilie's voice cut through the sound of rushing water. She flew through the air like a bird, dress and hair flying around her like wings.

Nathalie and Gabriel both rushed to the edge just in time to see her enter the water. It was a terrifying stretch of seconds they had to sit through before finally - *finally!!!* - her head appeared above the water, her laughter drifting up to them like birdsong.

"*Come on!*" she yelled, smiling brightly as she waved up at t*hem. "The water feels incredible!*"

"Emilie!" Nathalie yelled back, feeling her anxiety ease mostly and be replaced with displeasure. "Don't you know how dangerous that was?! What if there were rocks at the bottom?! You could've-!"

As Nathalie lectured Emilie, who bobbed in the water and smiled up at her, Gabriel stepped back a few paces. Nathalie heard him moving but paid it little attention; clearly that was her mistake as a few moments later he, just like his wife, ran forward and flung himself over the side, yelling gleefully. He splashed into the plunge pool, waves from his entry making Emilie bob up and down while she laughed riotously. A moment later, his head emerged from the water, hair plastered to his forehead and bright smile gleaming.

"Gabriel!" Nathalie's voice broke with her shock. No, not shock - she expected him to follow Emilie's lead in most things, after all - but *annoyance*. She *knew* the Agrestes had a death wish (they must've, given they always accompanied her even on expeditions better left solo), but she thought they could at least sit through a lecture *once*! She pinched the bridge of her nose and realized she clearly did *not* know them well enough yet.

"*Join us, Nathalie!*" Emilie called, waving up at her and completely ignoring the lecture she was in the middle of receiving. With a gleaming grin, she floated on her back and lightly kicked her feet, pushing herself in a circle. Her dress clung scandalously to her body, highlighting every curve and, in those areas on her thighs where her skirt was pushed up too high, the pale stretch of skin, so unlike the warm tan across the rest of her, that rarely saw the light of day. Most of her hair flowed around her shoulders in the pool, following the water current, and that hair which didn't was plastered to her forehead like a skintight cap.

"*Come on, Nathalie!*" Gabriel called happily, ignorant - or uncaring - of the annoyance she was feeling. *"It's completely safe!*" He bobbed in the water, paddling his arms and kicking his feet to remain vertical. Having opted for his full-white cotton-linen blended set while getting dressed this morning, Gabriel was almost as, or possibly even *more* exposed than, Emilie was; the motion of the water and his own movement did well enough to disrupt the view, but his collarbones peeked through his shirt and his underwear, a gray color, was just barely noticeable through his see-through clothing when the light shone brightly on him. His hair, stuck to his forehead when he first came above the water, was stuck to his forehead, but he pushed it back with his hand and it was now sleek and tight to his skull, an almost funny sight given how rarely he ever had his hair unstyled.

Nathalie looked down at them for just a moment, then turned around and walked away from the edge, pinching the bridge of her nose. They were trying to kill her; they clearly *wanted* to, given the ways they enjoyed endangering themselves. If she had a weak heart, she would've died from their antics long ago.

With a sigh to release tension, she felt the burning caress of the sun glaring down onto her. Despite the pale clothing and strong sunscreen she wore, the heat was still attempting to best her; it was, it seemed, getting close, if the sweat that dripped down her skin was any indication. If she'd been smart, she would've at least brought a bottle of water with her, something to drink to stave off dehydration. *Didn't she know better by now?* Though, then again, they were only fifteen minutes away from the hotel, and hadn't *planned* on getting lost. The cool water called to Nathalie and she wondered whether it were safe to drink; surely the fresh water wasn't *completely* unsafe to drink, or else the birds in the forest would've all been dead, right?

"*Weren't you supposed to collect your kiss?*" Emilie shouted, her voice just barely audible over the roar of the waterfall.

Nathalie stiffened, then walked quickly to the edge. "The time for that was before you tried to kill yourself," she called back with a glare.

Emilie's smile was mischievous and teasing. "*Then you don't mind if I give it to Gabriel?*" She called back, swimming on her back over to her husband.

Nathalie's mouth was dry and sweat dripped from her temple down her cheek. Expression neutral, she yelled back, "He's your *husband*. That seems natural."

She wasn't being stubborn, really; this was a game, as much as any other the trio liked to play. It was true she was annoyed at their carelessness - something they never *truly* seemed to get better about - but, as with countless trips and expeditions before it, she would lecture them later and hope it would stick for once. For now, she was waiting for the right moment, not to lecture... but to *join*.

Rather than firing back, Emilie rolled her eyes and turned away from Nathalie, instead facing Gabriel. He looked at Emilie with a knowing smile, muttering something that Nathalie couldn't quite read, before Emilie grabbed his shirt and dragged him into a kiss. It looked almost comical, the way they had to swim while their lips were locked, though the silliness of the situation didn't seem to occur to them.

The kiss was chaste enough at first, just a sweet peck between a married couple, though it quickly transformed; as Gabriel found, it seemed, a tall enough rock underwater to stand on, he was able to grab Emilie and hold her close, removing the need for both of them to focus on floating. They were able to deepen the kiss, Emilie tilting her head the way Nathalie had seen her do a thousand times, arms wrapping around Gabriel's neck as Gabriel's hand caressed her cheek, his other arm wrapped around her waist. Emilie's face was hidden from view, but Nathalie could see the movement of Gabriel's mouth from this angle, the pink dart of their tongues, before he broke away to kiss down her neck, nudging aside her wet hair to grant himself easier access. Emilie leaned back, allowing him to kiss down her collarbones and cleavage, but, Nathalie knew, more with the goal of looking back at her, crouched on the edge of the waterfall and unabashedly watching the show. Emilie's laugh was silent, her taunt unspoken, but Nathalie knew what she was saying anyway:

Hurry up or you'll be left behind.

Nathalie stalked away from the edge quickly, feeling the heat of the couple below greater suddenly than the sun. Not far away sat Emilie's sandals, kicked haphazardly to the side, as well as Gabriel's shoes, neatly placed together, and his glasses sitting atop them. Nathalie, not a fan of drenched clothing, was more thorough in undressing; she kicked off her water shoes (ironic given what she was about to do, though she accepted the risk), then shed her pants and shirt both, using them to cover the Agrestes shoes and Gabriel's glasses - an old trick she'd learned so nothing would heat up to a painful level in the sun. Standing in only her underwear, a pair of maroon boyshorts and a matching sports bra, she finally pulled her hair down, letting the ebony curtains tumble down her back; it was better down than eventually tangled in the hair tie that wouldn't support it when wet.

The threat of rocks at the bottom of the waterfall the Agrestes missed but which she might not didn't deter her; this was, frankly, less dangerous than climbing the tree had been. She took a few more steps back, the heat of the rock burning the soles of her feet, then ran forward, launching herself off of the edge in an elegant dive. As she neared the water, she saw Gabriel and Emilie break apart in surprise when her shadow drifted across them. Emilie's cheer rang out a moment before Nathalie cleanly entered the pool, cutting through the water like the silk Gabriel always kept in the atelier.

The waves swallowed her, clear blue licking up her body as it enveloped her. The water was cool, like snowmelt off a mountain, and it shocked her like lightning striking. Her eyes open underwater, she could see that the bottom of the pond was filled mostly with pebbles, no truly large rocks in sight. Even the pebbles were all flat and smooth, either ground down by the current or chosen and placed specifically for their soft edges. A few fish swam around the water, though they stayed close to the bottom and darted away when Nathalie got too close. With a mental sigh of relief that there was one less obstacle that could kill her employers, Nathalie finally surfaced with a gasp.

"I was wondering when you would resurface," Gabriel, a few meters away, warmly said, smiling as she swam over to him. Before Nathalie could ask, he said, "Emilie's gone to jump in again."

Nathalie blew a bubble in the water, hiding her mouth in case her displeasure was too visible. She'd been hoping for the promised kiss, now that she could finally relax; after all, there was nothing to worry about in the water, and the climbing path was quite easy to navigate, assuming you *weren't hurt*-

"She insisted," Gabriel said wryly, watching the top of the waterfall as Nathalie turned to him.

"You couldn't catch her in time," Nathalie replied, matching his tone and understanding his meaning.

He smiled shyly over at her. "Well... she swam off right after you hit the water," he agreed. "I didn't see where she was going until..."

Nathalie sighed and rolled her eyes, but couldn't stop herself from smiling at Emilie's antics. Gabriel chuckled, his expression boyish and youthful.

"Here, Nathalie," he took her hand in the water. "There's a shallow spot here."

He pulled her through the water to him, dragging her closer until he could properly wrap his arm around her waist and she could just barely find a foothold on the elevated rocks. Nathalie hummed softly as her side pressed to his, her hip meeting his own. This close, she could see the pink on his cheeks, now more likely indicative of sunburn than blush, as well as the wetness of his lips and the lock of hair that hung over his forehead, already drying outside of the water.

She reached up and brushed the lock of hair back into the rest, smearing water across his forehead. He leaned into her touch, eyes closing. His eyelashes, tiny droplets of water clinging to them, fanned over his cheekbones.

"I can always count on you to look out for me," He muttered softly.

"Always," she agreed, her hand gently combing through his hair.

Lazily, his eyes opened, blue-gray irises suddenly gleaming vibrant blue in the light reflected from the water. He met her gaze, then began to lower his head as she, hand tightening in his

shirt, leaned up to meet him. Their lips just brushed-

A sharp whistle cut through the air and they both startled, looking for the source. At the top of the waterfall, Nathalie spotted her and pointed her out to Gabriel: Emilie, fully nude, grinning and waving.

"She's naked," Nathalie said aloud, frowning. She wasn't really surprised, given Emilie's enjoyment of freedom and nudity both, though it was a rather bold choice to make given the public nature of the location.

"Wha-?" Gabriel was gobsmacked. "*Here?!* But what if someone see-"

"*You're not having fun without me, are you?*" Emilie yelled down jubilantly. "*Here i come!*"

Before Gabriel could contest the nudity, Emilie jumped. Her body glistened in the sunlight like she were made of stars, constellations born of sweat and pond water sparkling over her, and her smile was visible, like she held the crescent moon in her mouth. She looked *celestial*, like a shooting star on collision course with the water. She entered it with a great splash, ripples cascading away from her as she broke the surface a moment later, hair covering her face.

Gabriel swam immediately to her, awkwardly trying to remove his shirt as he kicked. "Emilie!" he chastised, finally hovering in the water next to her. "Put this on! There could be other people-" he tried to push his shirt to her but she laughed and pushed it away.

Emilie skirted around him with a laugh, darting through the water to Nathalie's side. As Nathalie gripped her tightly, helping her stand on the narrow rock, Emilie tossed her hair, showering both of them in water droplets.

"There's nobody here but *us*, Gabriel," she replied with a giggle, looking over her shoulder at him. "And besides, what is there to see anyway? It's *just* a body."

"*Your* body," Gabriel reminded her with a grimace, shirt still clutched in his fist. With both women on the rock and no extra space to be found, he was forced to swim in the water next to them instead. "You're *famous*, Emilie! There could be hidden cameras, or paparazzi, or-"

"*Nathalie* doesn't want me to get dressed," Emilie argued, smiling. She faced Nathalie again, leaning into her until their bodies were pressed together, Emilie's unclothed breasts pressed to Nathalie's. Her voice dipped lower as she seductively asked, "*Do you?*"

Nathalie knew what Gabriel wanted her to say, but she also knew what she herself wanted to say. She chuckled softly and lowered her head, dipping her mouth to Emilie's ear, and said, "Not exactly."

Gabriel glared halfheartedly. "I never know whose side you're going to be on," he said with a frown.

"Just *relax*, my love," Emilie laughed, playfully flicking a bit of water at him. "It'll be fine! What's the worst that could happen - someone take a picture and we have to sue?" She

scoffed and rolled her eyes. "Besides... do you *really* want to swim around in wet clothing?"

"I..." Gabriel hesitated, grimacing.

"Go on," she waved her hand like a queen might. "Go lay your clothing in the sun and jump in again; it's so exciting!"

"I'm *not* jumping in nude," Gabriel deadpanned. "There are certain parts of my anatomy I would rather not risk landing in the water wrong with."

Emilie stuck her tongue out at him. "*You* will, won't you, Nathalie?" she asked, fluttering her eyes at Nathalie. It was a needless gesture, though endearing all the same.

"I wonder," Nathalie teasingly replied, softly kissing the juncture between Emilie's shoulder and neck. Her skin felt so soft suddenly, as though the simple act of removing her clothing had suddenly softened her substantially.

As Nathalie broke away and swam towards the bank, Emilie hooked a deft hand in Gabriel's waistband and dragged him closer in the water, ignoring his protests. On the shore, water dripping down her body and pooling under her feet, Nathalie looked back at them and smiled to herself as she watched them wrestle, Emilie trying to strip Gabriel as Gabriel pretended not to enjoy it. How would it all change once the Miraculous was found? With a child in the mix, the prophesied son, blonde hair and green eyes and a love as warm as the sun? Pebbles turned to sand which turned to soil under her feet as she took the path to the top, Emilie and Gabriel's voices growing more faint as she did.

A few minutes later, at the top of the waterfall once more, a welcome breeze cooled the last of the water on Nathalie's skin. Emilie's dress was haphazardly laid out, partially folded on itself in her haste to cast it aside, and Nathalie took a moment to straighten it, ensuring maximum sun exposure so that it would properly dry. Next, she pulled her sports bra over her head, stepped out of her boyshorts, and laid them both out to dry next to the rest of her clothes. Unbothered by any potential unwanted eyes watching her, she stepped to the very edge of the waterfall.

Without announcing herself, Nathalie dived again, the water accepting her without even a hint of struggle. It was a smooth caress, like the barely-there drag of fingers against her skin, the current roving over her and mapping her every inch before spriting, as though a full-body inspection was conducted and passed. She swam close to the bottom of the river, glittering caustics dancing merrily over her skin as she moved through the water.

As she neared Emilie and Gabriel, she could see Emilie watching her above the surface of the water, her smile mischievous - probably because of the hand she had inside Gabriel's pants. His body leaned into Emilie's as though for strength, his hold on her almost girlish in comparison. Nathalie swam behind him, brushing against the rocks, and trailed her own hands up his legs, long calves and muscular to muscular thighs, as she broke the surface of the water. She panted against his back, not enough room on the rock to properly stand so she had to hook her arm around his hips as, kicking her feet to stay above water, she caught her breath.

As though barely aware of Nathalie, Gabriel whimpered, shivering from Emilie's steady, but slow stroking.

"The water is so smooth, there's hardly any friction at all," Emilie murmured, biting her lip as she watched her motion through the water. "Nathalie, be a dear, won't you?"

Emilie rarely had to specify her requests; the two knew each other too well to need it. In this instance, Emilie wanted Nathalie to undress Gabriel, to get her way, and Nathalie was only too eager to assist. Her hands crept slid onto Gabriel's hips, her face pressed to his back. He wasn't very loud, but his soft whines and whimpers made his back flex under her cheek, his skin warm against hers. He didn't stop her as she began to ease his pants down, though one of his hands moved from Emilie's hip to Nathalie's wrist.

When his pants were at his mid-calf and he still didn't step from them, Emilie giggled. She stopped stroking him, ignoring his wrecked whine, and instead slid her hands up his chest, lower body grinding against his in the water as she looped her arms around his neck.

"*I love you*," she whispered against his lips, her smile seductive and mischievous. It was the only warning he had before she pushed hard against him and he slid slipped backwards into the deeper water with a yelp.

Acting as more trickster than maiden, Nathalie dived into the water again and, expertly dodging his kicking feet as he worked to keep his head above the water, she pulled his pants off the rest of the way and stole his shirt from his fist, quickly swimming backwards as he tried to grab her.

"Emilie," Gabriel whined brokenly as Nathalie emerged again. "Must I beg?"

"Don't tempt me," Emilie tittered, now swimming herself. "I got what I wanted - go ahead, step up again." As he did so, Emilie swam past Nathalie and discreetly grabbed his clothing from her. She didn't even have to ask Nathalie to take her place; Nathalie did so immediately.

If Gabriel was surprised by the change, he barely showed it. Instead, as Emilie climbed out of the water and limped her way to the trail, he sighed as Nathalie took Emilie's previous spot, hip to hip with him. She grabbed hold of his length, bobbing in the water and a beautiful pinkish-red in the bright light. The water cooled it slightly from what she knew the usual temperature to be, and the water, just as Emilie had noted, removed almost all friction as she began to pump her hand. Unlike Emilie, who watched her own actions as she did them, Nathalie leaned into Gabriel and watched his face, the way his blush deepened and water dripped down his cheeks, his pupils mere pinpricks in the light.

"You both want to kill me," he muttered, voice low as though to lecture.

Nathalie laughed quietly, her speed increasing. "I know more effective ways, if you'd prefer."

He groaned softly, grabbing her upper arm as he leaned into her, burying his face in her neck. His breath was hot and ragged in her ear as he replied, "I don't think you realize just how *effective* this is."

Behind them both was the sound of a splash, undoubtedly that of Emilie reentering the water. Nathalie looked back just long enough to watch her resurface safely before returning her attention to him. His lips were on her neck, not quite moving with the purpose of creating a mark, but rather with the soft open and close of his panting, tongue darting out every now and again to lick his lips and send a current of electricity up her spine.

"Nathalie..." he muttered, hand around her back dragging her into his chest.

"*Sir*," Nathalie replied with a smirk.

Gabriel grit his teeth, moaning into her neck as he humped her hand for the final few strokes it took to push him over the edge. She tightened her grip and slowed her strokes, easing his release from him just the way she knew he liked. It floated in the water between them, milk white barely visible in the bright sunlight, as Gabriel sagged in her arms and she finally released his member. He sighed against her neck, arms draped over her in a loose hug.

Across the calm stillness came the sound of swimming, and they both looked up to see Emilie cutting through the water aiming for them. As she neared, she slowed down, bobbing in place, and grinned brightly.

"Have you two finished yet? Come see- there's a cave behind the waterfall, just like in a movie!" she excitedly said. Before they had s chance to reply, she turned tail and quickly began swimming, kicking feet spraying them with water. With a warm smile at each other, they released each other and swam after her.

Behind the waterfall, halfway up the cliff face, was a cave inset into the rock. It was impressively hidden, only visible when already climbing the wall; it was unlikely anybody would notice it if they weren't already looking for it. Emilie, adventurous as she was, almost definitely had been, and she disappeared into the mouth of the cave a moment after Gabriel and Nathalie swam behind the waterfall, leaving them to scramble up after her; Gabriel nearly slipped, catching himself at the last moment, and Nathalie nearly ripped a nail off in her haste, but eventually they were both able to make it up to the cave unscathed.

Standing in the middle of the cave, arms spread wide and water dripping off of her, Emilie said, "Isn't this so exciting?!"

They looked around themselves. It was just like dozens of caves the three of them had explored before; dark, wet, and surprisingly small inside. It was empty save for the three of them and some discarded items - mostly empty beer cans and bottles, though there was an empty pack of condoms hidden near some rocks, as well as a watch that looked to be broken and a few soggy towels lumped together in a corner.

"I guess this is where the employees go when they want privacy," Gabriel frowned, nudging a bottle with his foot; it rolled into another bottle, the two clinking together and stopping by a rock. "Er... *more* privacy."

"You've been in hidden caves several times before," Nathalie pointed out, walking over to Emilie. "Most of which were cleaner and more impressive than this."

Emilie rolled her eyes, still smiling, and said, "You two need to use your *imagination!* See, picture it..." Emilie walked behind Nathalie and stood on tiptoe to cover Nathalie's eyes with her hands. "Imagine sneaking away with your lover at night... the two of you visit the grotto where *dreams* are made... the moon shines onto your naked bodies as you swim together, nobody around to ruin the moment..." Her body pressed against Nathalie's back and she swayed as though to music only she could hear. "Suddenly, your lover grabs you by the hand and kisses you! The passion grows until you separate just long enough to make it into the cave...." Nathalie could feel Emilie's heart beating against her back, racing at the thought. Nathalie thought Emilie might've subtly been grinding against her. "The roar of the water hides the sound of you both making love, but that's alright because you can *feel* the love in the air!" She sighed longingly and dropped her hands from Nathalie's eyes. "*Now* can't you see it?" she asked, smiling.

Nathalie blinked, then looked over her shoulder at Emilie. "You're about to step on a used condom," she pointed out.

Emilie squealed, then laughed, dancing away. "Gabriel, can't *you* see my vision? Isn't it simply *stunning?*" She asked him, hopeful.

"Of course, my love," he agreed readily, one hand pressed over his heart. "It's beautiful."

Nathalie didn't say it was probably because he wasn't wearing glasses and couldn't see what it really looked like inside the cave anyway.

Emilie hummed and snapped her fingers. "I know- Gabriel, hum a song for us, won't you?"

Gabriel straightened, flustered by the unexpected request. "A song?"

Emilie nodded, walking back to Nathalie (and giving a wide berth to the used condom). "Something slow and beautiful! You know what i like."

Gabriel hesitated, then closed his eyes. Hand tapping a beat on his thigh, foot tapping at the same time, he began to hum. The acoustics of the cave were solid, allowing his voice to echo and make the space seem deeper than it actually was.

Emilie grabbed Nathalie's hand and drew her in. Rather than the kiss, that long-awaited reward, Nathalie expected, Emilie instead lead her in a waltz, and together they dodged the various obstacles in their way. Emilie's own voice joined Gabriel's, weaving together a song Nathalie finally recognized as having played at their wedding (at least according to their retelling of events, since the three of them didn't know each other back then). Her heart jumped painfully, a loving ache in her chest that made her throat tighten.

"It's just so *romantic*," Emilie sighed, eyes closed. "Can you picture it *now*?"

Eyes only on Emilie, careless and free, Nathalie felt herself soften. Smoothly, she took the leading role from Emilie, the two twirling around the confined space. As the song drew to a close, they came to a stop in the center of the cave. The last few notes ringing through the air, Gabriel's humming coming to a close, Nathalie dipped her low, Emilie's hair just barely dragging across the floor.

"Yes," Nathalie agreed softly as Emilie's eyes slowly cracked open. "I can see it."

Emilie smiled up at her, then caressed her cheek. Their lips met in the middle, soft and warm as her touch. As it deepened, Nathalie straightened, pulling Emilie up with her lest they fall. Their torsos pressed together, warm flesh to warm flesh, and Emilie's manicured nails dug into Nathalie's back, holding her close as though afraid she would run away.

With the hand that'd been on Nathalie's cheek, Emilie beckoned to Gabriel, who'd been watching them from the side, and he joined them. He and Emilie kissed with youthful vigor, but Emilie, ever the tease, pulled away from him just as quickly to kiss Nathalie again, as though trying to stoke a competitive spirit. Undeterred, he wrapped himself around her back, grasping her hips as she shamelessly fondled Nathalie's breasts, pale flesh spilling from between her fingers. She softly moaned as though just the act of being touched was erotic enough to stoke a fire within her, and she switched from Nathalie's mouth to Gabriel's over her shoulder.

Nathalie was the first to get down on her knees.

She nuzzled against Emilie's thigh, rubbing her cheek against the soft skin like she was trying to memorize it, as though one day in the far future she would no longer be able to touch it, feel it, caress it, kiss and bite it. Gabriel's hands roved Emilie's chest as they kissed, Emilie's chest already heaving as though knowing what was coming. With the practiced ease of experience, Nathalie nudged Emilie's legs open, crawling between them until her goal was revealed to her, brownish-pink cunt glistening not just from the water they'd been in, but from her own arousal. Emilie moaned into Gabriel's mouth as Nathalie's tongue, long and wide and warm, slowly licked upwards. Emilie's thighs shook around her head as Nathalie's nose nuzzled into the trimmed blonde hair on her pelvis, tongue fluttering against her clit.

"G-Gabriel," Emilie panted, voice breaking as Nathalie's lips suctioned around her clit, "in fro- get in *front* of me."

Gabriel moved around the pair as Emilie stumbled backwards a few steps, clearly frustrating herself though not enough to continue. "Lay down, Nathalie."

Emilie wet her own lips as Nathalie wordlessly obeyed. The rock floor was hard and unyielding, Nathalie's only comfort on it her own hair, which she shoved under her head to soften the hard floor. Emilie knelt and Nathalie's hands grasped her thighs, obediently opening her mouth once more. As soon as Emilie was situated (notable by the way she moaned as Nathalie's tongue lapped at her again), she leaned towards Gabriel. Already hard, she merely pumped his cock a few times to warm up, before she pressed her cheek to it, heated eyes locking on his own. Gabriel brushed a few strands of hair from Emilie's face, and she smiled lovingly up at him in return.

Gabriel jolted as Emilie licked up his shaft. His hand in her hair wasn't there to direct her - instead, it was there so he had something to ground himself, as though he might drift away with her ministrations if he didn't have it. She did it again, flattening her tongue and dragging it upwards slower, completely at odds with the faster pace Nathalie was taking underneath her. As though she had all the time in the world, she thoroughly coated his length with her saliva, still pumping him occasionally as she moaned, and when finally she was happy with

her work, she took the head into her mouth, moaning again as she swirled her tongue around the tip.

Nathalie picked up her pace, nails digging into Emilie's thighs. Her own core throbbed, aroused merely by the act of service, and she could just barely hear Emilie's muffled moan in return. A muscle in her jaw ached, the rock underneath her head was hard, and yet she ignored them both, so focused on her task she barely remembered to breathe (not that asphyxiation between Emilie Agreste's legs would've been a bad death). Emilie's voice was picking up, echoing through the rocks, and Nathalie's and Gabriel's voices joined it in return, a chorus of pleasure and lust filling the cave for what was almost certainly not the first time. It felt as though the air itself was heating up, their bodies moving in tandem.

Precum leaked into Emilie's mouth as she sucked his tip, bobbing her head as she slowly took him deeper into her mouth. Gabriel looked almost wrecked, like he was in heaven, and his hips moved on occasion, as though he couldn't quite stop himself. His moans were soft but desperate, his shaking hand in her hair matching the rest of his trembling body. His tip prodded at her throat and saliva dripped from between her lips and down her chin as she swallowed back a choked cough, forcefully moaning to hopefully staunch the reflex instead. One fist, the one not wrapped around his cock, pressed her thumb into her palm in an attempt to staunch her gag reflex. At the same time, her eyes were watering, though this not from the cock at her throat - rather, from the tongue at her cunt. Emilie was pitifully close in what felt like record time, Nathalie truly giving it her all without stopping.

Nathalie was moaning far louder than any woman not even being touched had any right to. Her thighs clenched together as she forced herself not to writhe, pleasure already intense; maybe it made her pathetic to be so aroused without anybody assisting her, but she couldn't find it in herself to care, hadn't been able to find that urge ever since she joined the Agrestes. She could tell Emilie was close, from the way the woman shook, to the way her stomach, Nathalie's fingers against it where Nathalie held her hips, tightened, to the way Emilie subtly throbbed in her mouth. Nathalie pursed her lips around Emilie's clit and pulled Emilie harder against herself, holding Emilie in place for the greatest assault on her senses yet.

Emilie cried out around Gabriel's cock as her orgasm hit her, eyes fluttering. She ground down against Nathalie, all but forgetting to move her head for a moment as she chased the sensation. As though subconsciously waiting for this distraction, she pressed her head forward, burying her nose in Gabriel's pubes, fully embedding him in her throat. Her moans were distorted as he shallowly thrust his hips against her, breathily moaning her name, *Emilie, Emilie, Emilie*. It was a chorus Nathalie would repeat if she could, mouth busy but heart singing the same, *Emilie, Emilie, Emilie*.

As Emilie's own orgasm came down, afterglow settling over her, limbs warm and heavy and lungs almost ready to burst, Gabriel's thrusts grew sloppy and harder, his pelvis pressing against her nose and the heat of his skin warming her cheek. She could feel the vein up the side of his cock throb against her tongue a moment before he pulled out of her mouth. She took great, gasping breaths of air as, holding himself in fist, he orgasmed, cum splattering against her cheek. Like a good wife, she sat there and waited, ignoring the passing - and useless - thought that she shouldn't "let it go to waste".

After a long moment, Gabriel and Emilie's heavy breathing filling the air, Emilie leaned back enough to reveal Nathalie, face flushed and eyes wide. Emilie's hand crept down Nathalie's stomach, but when it reached Nathalie's pelvis, Nathalie stopped it, instead grabbing her hand and squeezing it. Their eyes met, a silent conversation passing between them, before Emilie smiled softly and nodded.

In the comfortable silence, Gabriel stepped back, softening cock shiny with Emilie's spit, and offered her his hand. She took it, smiling, and he helped her to her feet, fully freeing Nathalie in the process. Legs numb, Emilie stumbled into his chest and he held her there, pressing his forehead to hers.

"I love you," he whispered softly. She kissed him as Nathalie slowly sat up.

Together, Gabriel and Emilie both offered Nathalie their hands and loving smiles. She took them both, the expression on her face so genuinely sweet and loving it was almost heartbreaking. No sooner was she standing up than they both latched onto her, showering her with kisses until, in a she laughed, a rare sound that they loved to chase after again and again.

The three held each other, none quite ready to speak just yet. Nathalie's head rest on Gabriel's chest, her ear to his heart, and her arm was around Emilie's back, holding her gently. Gabriel had an arm around her waist, softly stroking her back, and his head was resting against Emilie's. Emilie had one hand on Gabriel's hip and another on Nathalie's waist, head against Nathalie's chest, lips against Nathalie's breast. They wouldn't have moved at all yet, except-

"Oh, shit-"

As a unit, the three turned to face the entrance of the cave. There, one of the hotel employees - namely the receptionist, who saw them daily and who told Emilie about the grotto in the first place - was just finishing his climb into the cave, though he froze with one foot still on the rock wall and his face bright red.

"Sorry, I didn't know you were- I-I was just looking for my watch-!"

After that was a flurry of motion; Nathalie unashamedly shielded both of the Agrestes bodies with her own, Gabriel seemed nearly speechless with shock and vindication, face turning a bright, splotchy red as he covered himself with one hand and tried to cover his wife with the other, and Emilie laughing jubilantly, apologizing between giggles and trying to engage the awkward man, who was trying to look everywhere but at them, in conversation. At some point, either pitying him or trying to get him to leave faster, Nathalie grabbed the broken watch she'd seen earlier and shoved it into his hand, at which point he immediately absconded, babbled apologized still tumbling from him. After that, the trio quickly vacated the cave, splashed into the water below, swam to the shore, trekked to the top of the waterfall and redressed in their thankfully dry clothing, and began their hike back to the hotel.

"Once we're in the room, I'll massage your ankle," Nathalie said to Emilie, who she was carrying on her back. "You shouldn't have stressed it as much as you did."

"Once we're in the room," Emilie corrected, knuckle brushing Nathalie's cheekbone, "*you're* getting what you didn't want back there." She frowned, then added, "If you want it." She

looked over at Gabriel, who still looked vaguely mortified but who was slowly relaxing with each step. "Right, Gabriel."

He jumped, then looked shyly over at the women. "That's- yes, of course," he agreed, distracted. "Do the employees of the resort have NDAs, do you think?"

Emilie laughed, then leaned back into Nathalie. "Ignore him; you know how easy it is to get him on the right track. So, what was it back there that stopped you, hmm?" She kicked her legs lightly. "I think that's one of the first times you've ever turned me down."

Nathalie's wry smile was just visible to Emilie as she said, "I didn't want to risk a UTI after all of the playing in the dirt you did today."

Emilie snorted. "Good point!" She praised. "We can all wash up when we get back, and then..." Emilie lowered her voice and whispered in Nathalie's ear, "You're ours for the rest of the night."

"*You* need to rest," Nathalie stressed, her smile soft and her cheeks pink. "And *Gabriel* will probably want me to scare the receptionist before he tells anybody what he saw."

Emilie groaned halfheartedly, slumping against Nathalie's back. "Sometimes I hate how well you know us."

"Do you?" Nathalie asked, her teasing.

Emilie was quiet for a moment, then sighed again. "No," she admitted dramatically. She patted Nathalie's shoulders like one might pat the haunches of a horse, then said, "Fine, have it your way, but *don't forget* we'll have you our way later!"

"We're too close to the resort for you to say that," Nathalie said, smiling. Ahead, the beach was drawing nearer, resort patrons enjoying the sun and the waves.

"Emilie, someone could hear you!" Gabriel said at the same time, a quiet whine to his voice as though he were imagining some socialite spreading the story later.

Emilie's laugh rang across the beach as they exited the trees and stepped onto the sandy white beach.

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